

First Read

Hong Kong Banks

Thoughts on tighter trading account controls and mainland outbound investment rules

Equities

Hong Kong
Banks

Additional procedures for investment account management for mainland Chinese investors

Following the CSRC's [crackdown on illegal cross-border securities trading](#), the HKMA introduced [additional measures for authorized institutions](#) in relation to the opening and management of investment accounts held by mainland Chinese investors using mainland China-issued identification documents. In response, Hong Kong banks tightened controls on new trading account openings, requiring these investors to sign declarations covering the source of funds, document authenticity, and prior records, including confirmation that the funds were lawfully sourced outside mainland China. Since Hong Kong banks have diversified business lines, securities investment services for mainland Chinese investors likely account for only a small share of total revenue. Local Hong Kong banks could face greater pressure than international peers, given the meaningful contribution of cross-border clients to their customer base. That said, existing KYC and AML requirements should help limit the overall financial impact. We nevertheless expect new customer growth to moderate in the near term, as mainland Chinese clients have been a key growth driver over the past two to three years. For example, BOCHK reported that its cross-border high-end customer base grew by more than 20% YoY, while wealth management income rose by 40% in 2025. BEA also recorded double-digit growth in its southbound cross-boundary client base, AUM, and revenue in 2025. Although implementation details are still pending, the near-term impact appears manageable.

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Tighter outbound investment rules add further friction to capital flows

Separately, China's State Council announced a new regulation on mainland outbound investments, effective 1 July 2026. We expect the new framework to lead to closer scrutiny of outbound investments and, in turn, to weigh further on banks' corporate banking growth, particularly in business linked to mainland Chinese entities. In 2025, China's trade surplus reached US\$1.2tn, compared with only a US\$155.5bn increase in foreign exchange reserves, which may suggest that a significant share of funds is being held offshore, with Hong Kong likely serving as one of the key destinations. In our view, mainland China-related business contributes a double-digit share of revenue for local Hong Kong banks, as reflected in non-bank China exposure accounting for 40% of the banking system's loan portfolio. Against this backdrop, tighter scrutiny of capital flows could create downside risk for excess deposits, cash management and custodian services, insurance product distribution, and securities and brokerage trading. Overall, the measure adds another layer of uncertainty for the sector in the near term.

Valuation: Reiterate Neutral on BOCHK and BEA

Tighter regulations are likely to weigh on market sentiment in the near term. For BOCHK, we view valuation as stretched at 1.4x 2026E P/B, with a dividend yield of 4.9%, and we continue to monitor further details of the three-year shareholder framework. For BEA, while the stock appears undemanding at 0.3x 2026E P/B, the key question remains where credit cost will settle in 2026, as this will be an important indicator of its progress toward the 7% ROE target by 2028.

Valuation Method and Risk Statement

Hong Kong banks are large, highly leveraged financial institutions operating across a number of markets, and as such are subject to the risk of changes in the general business and economic conditions within these markets. A change in these conditions could include changes in interest rates, inflation, unemployment, monetary supply, exogenous shocks, foreign exchange rates, and the health of the general economy. The banks also face the risk of regulatory changes and increased competition, which could affect the profitability of the sector. A key risk that financial institutions face is associated with extending credit to other parties. Less favourable business conditions could cause potential losses from loans to increase, thereby putting pressure on the group's capital. The bank sector also faces operational risk from operating such large and complex businesses.

Our price targets are derived using a DDM based valuation approach.

Upside risks BOCHK include: 1) faster-than-expected economic recovery in mainland China and Hong Kong; 2) faster balance sheet expansion at or above current profitability; and 3) stronger-than expected recovery in capital market, driving up fee income. Downside risks to our Neutral rating on BOCHK include: 1) slower-than-expected economic recovery that weighs on both NIM and loan growth; 2) higher asset quality risk from mainland/HK CRE and Southeast Asia exposure, 3) prolonged weakness in capital market performance that weighs on fee income.

Upside risks for BEA include: 1) strong policy loosening in China's property sector; 2) delayed and reduced Fed rate cuts; and 3) further restructuring plans involving disposal of low-return operating segments. Downside risks include: 1) worse-than-expected NPL trends especially in the bank's China property developer loan book; and 2) unsatisfactory dividend payout policies.

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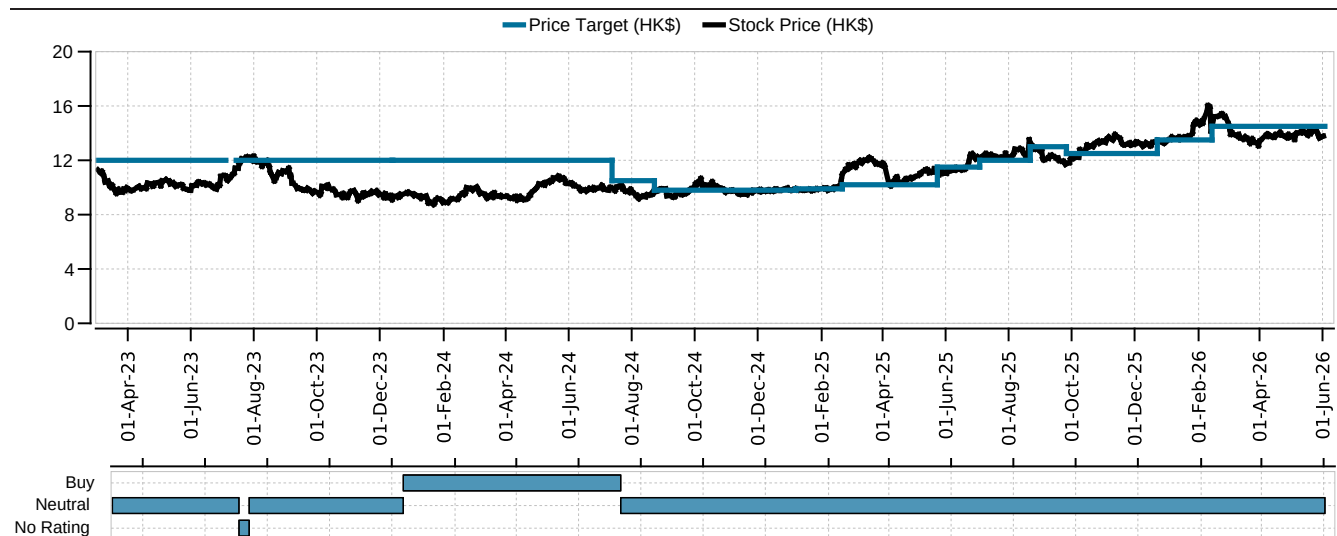
Company Name	Reuters	12-month rating	Price	Price date
Bank of China (Hong Kong) ^{16,28,7,6a,6b}	2388.HK	Neutral	HK\$48.00	02 Jun 2026
Bank of East Asia ^{28,7,6a,6b}	0023.HK	Neutral	HK\$13.78	02 Jun 2026

Source: UBS Global Research; LSEG Eikon. All prices as of local market close. Ratings in this table are the most current published ratings prior to this report. They may be more recent than the stock pricing date.

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Bank of East Asia (HK\$)

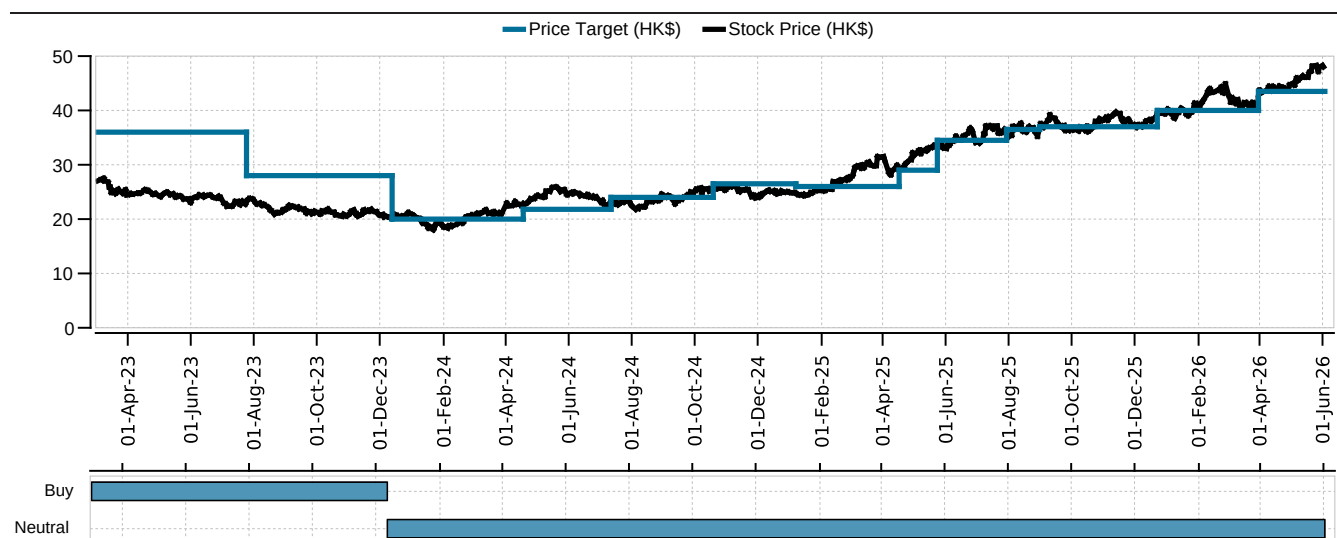


Date	Stock Price (HK\$)	Price Target (HK\$)	Rating
2023-03-02	11.10	12.00	Neutral
2023-07-04	10.86	-	No Rating
2023-07-14	11.42	12.00	Neutral
2023-12-12	9.41	12.00	Buy
2024-07-12	10.00	10.50	Neutral
2024-08-22	9.55	9.80	Neutral
2025-01-06	9.90	9.90	Neutral
2025-02-20	10.56	10.20	Neutral
2025-05-23	11.28	11.50	Neutral
2025-07-03	12.20	12.00	Neutral
2025-08-21	13.52	13.00	Neutral
2025-09-25	11.70	12.50	Neutral

Date	Stock Price (HK\$)	Price Target (HK\$)	Rating
2025-12-22	13.32	13.50	Neutral
2026-02-13	14.14	14.50	Neutral

Source: UBS Global Research; LSEG Eikon as of 02-Jun-2026. All prices as of local market close. Ratings as of date shown.

Bank of China (Hong Kong) (HK\$)



Date	Stock Price (HK\$)	Price Target (HK\$)	Rating
2023-03-02	26.90	36.00	Buy
2023-07-24	22.75	28.00	Buy
2023-12-12	20.45	20.00	Neutral
2024-04-17	22.55	21.80	Neutral
2024-07-11	23.00	24.00	Neutral
2024-10-18	25.60	26.50	Neutral
2025-01-06	24.90	26.00	Neutral
2025-04-16	29.25	29.00	Neutral
2025-05-23	33.55	34.50	Neutral
2025-07-29	36.40	36.50	Neutral
2025-08-30	35.22	37.00	Neutral
2025-12-22	38.98	40.00	Neutral
2026-03-30	40.54	43.50	Neutral

Source: UBS Global Research; LSEG Eikon as of 02-Jun-2026. All prices as of local market close. Ratings as of date shown.

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